

Low share of income originating from sales of products shows that much of the income is achieved from the operation of fixed assets. At the end of 2010, cooperatives had an estimated number of 50.000 members, two of three members being employed and earning incomes of 6,500 Euros per member and about 10 thousand Euros per employee. Credit Unions Credit Unions (known in Romania under the name Casa de Ajutor Reciproc Houses of Mutual Aid - CAR) are organisations of social economy, legally established as non-profit associations, and having the purpose of providing small interest loans to its members, especially for consumer needs, but also to support or cover special situations (i.e. funeral expenses, marriage costs etc). There are two main types of credit unions – of the employees - CARS Casa de Ajutor Reciproc a Salariatilor (which now include also self-employed persons) and of the retired - CARP Casa de Ajutor Reciproc a Pensionarilor, with two separate laws that regulate them. The credit unions of the employees can only conduct credit related activities while those of the retired may engage in other services for their members. CARPs play a significant role in the development of associative feeling for ageing people, and they can be viable socio-economic alternatives for covering risks like exclusion from the credit market of people with low income, difficult access to health and proximity services for poor elderly people and support for poor people in difficult situations. In Romania, Pensioners' Credit Unions also provide access to certain types of social services, some CARPs being accredited for this purpose. CAR operates with its own funds, which, unlike cooperatives, are collective and indivisible, with no capital divided into distinct parts between members. Source of loans granted by credit unions is represented by the deposition of members into a personal account called "social fund", bearing interest, but which does not have a deposit account character. Credit unions are non-bank financial institutions, but they have not a status of institutions engaged in lending activities, on a professional basis. They are financial, but not credit institutions and the legal framework prohibits granting credits to legal entities and collecting deposits. They are required to be registered with National Bank of Romania Register, and their business is supervised by the Central Bank. Activity related to the work performed by the credit unions is exempt from taxes and fees. In the NBR Register, at the end of 2010 were recorded 2983 credit unions, from which 203 Pensioners' Credit Unions (7% from total) and 2780 Employees Credit Unions. The records of the National Association of Employees' Credit Unions (UNCARS) included a number of 2083 credit unions belonging to UNCARS at the end of 2010 (75%), the rest of 697 credit unions being affiliated to other federations, or no affiliated, and most of them belonging to the employees from military units, police or other structures of central administration. One of the most remarkable issue regarding credit unions, it is that from all the associative forms of social economy they have the biggest number of members (around 3,2 million persons). A percentage of 36% from total pensioners and 16% from total employees were members in a credit union at the end of 2010 in Romania. Sheltered workshops Sheltered workshops are considered to be part of social economy, in particular those functioning in the framework of associations and foundations that thus meet the social economy / social enterprise criteria . They are in many ways similar to Work Integration Social Enterprises - WISE and as such have been also included in CIRIEC report 201217 for Romania case (under the name of authorized protected units). Sheltered workshops, organizations with an important role in work integration of people with disabilities, are organizational forms very close to the model of work integration social enterprise. They are established, authorized and function according to the Law 448 / 6 December 2006 regarding the protection and the promotion of the rights of persons with disabilities. According to this law, sheltered workshops are independent organizations or sections with own management in organizations, which has at least 30% employees with disabilities working with individual labor contract in the total number of employees. Sheltered workshops are accessible to different legal forms (for profit companies, 17 CIRIEC – Centre International de recherches et d'information sur l'économie publique, sociale et cooperative (2012): Luis Monzon Campos & Rafael Chaves Avila „The social economy in the European Union”, p. 42.